

ADCLOD Podcast Series with Social Impact Founders

Episode 15: Dr. Rukmini Banerji, Pratham Education Foundation

Neharika Vohra: Welcome to the ADCLOD podcast series with social impact founders, an initiative by the Ashank Desai Centre for Leadership and Organisational Development at IIM Ahmedabad, where we document and celebrate the leadership journeys of India's homegrown social entrepreneurs and institution builders.

Neharika Vohra: In today's episode, we speak with Dr. Rukmini Banerji, who served as CEO of Pratham Education Foundation from 2015 to 2026 and is now its senior advisor. For nearly three decades, she has worked on one of the most persistent questions in Indian public life: why are so many children in school, but not learning? Founded in 1995 in the slums of Mumbai with a deceptively simple mission — "every child in school and learning well" — Pratham today reaches children and youth across more than 26 states and union territories. Pratham pioneered the Annual Status of Education Report, ASER, in 2005, which for the first time gave India an honest, district-level picture of the learning crisis in its primary schools. Its Teaching at the Right Level methodology, validated by J-PAL at MIT, is now implemented with more than half of India's state governments and has spread to 16 countries across sub-Saharan Africa. Dr. Banerji trained as an economist at St. Stephen's College, Delhi, the Delhi School of Economics, and Oxford as a Rhodes Scholar, and completed her PhD at the University of Chicago in 1991. She joined Pratham in 1996, directed the ASER Centre for a decade, and became CEO of Pratham in 2015. In 2008, Rukmini received the Maulana Abul Kalam Azad Shiksha Puraskar from the Government of Bihar — she was its first recipient — and in 2021 she was awarded the Yidan Prize for Education, the world's highest education accolade.

Neharika Vohra: We are so delighted to have you with us today, Rukmini. It's a pleasure and an honour to be speaking with you.

Rukmini Banerji: It's wonderful to be here, and I'm really looking forward to the conversation.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you, Rukmini. As I said, you work on one of the most difficult problems in the country — children go to school and don't learn, and many children still don't go to school at all. Pratham has been engaged with this problem for a long time. Could you give us a picture of what Pratham looks like today — its scale, the states it operates in, the communities it serves, the range of programmes, and the nature of the people working with you?

Rukmini Banerji: Today, Pratham is — whether you call it a team or a family — more than 5,000 full-time people. We are spread across almost all the states of India; we don't have a presence in Kerala or in a few states of the Northeast, but otherwise we have a big or small team almost everywhere. We work all the way from the pre-school age group to youth, and now, in some of our programmes, with older women as well. So we work across the age spectrum — obviously a lot in pre-school and primary school, but we do have programmes for youth. We started with education, but today we also have a big vertical helping young people enter the job market — vocational skilling, entrepreneurship and so on. And one of my favourite programmes helps older girls and women finish Class 10, which we call our Second Chance programme; a range of initiatives specifically for older girls and women are emerging around it.

That's who we are. Almost everybody in Pratham, other than me and a few others, is very young, and usually from the state in which they work — very often even from the same district. For many of our young people, Pratham is probably their first job, or their first assignment outside school; very often it's also the first time they've left home. So I feel very young, because I'm surrounded by so many young people. I'd say it is their work that makes Pratham who we are — and I'm sure we'll talk about this later — but I feel that if young people feel positive and hopeful, and see their contribution making a difference, then that is what development is all about.

Neharika Vohra: It's very interesting that you now work with the entire range of people in education. The Second Chance programme you spoke about — is it in all the states, or in some locations?

Rukmini Banerji: We are currently in about seven or eight states, but there's no reason — other than funding and so on — why it couldn't be elsewhere. Of course, there are now many states in which it's hard to find people who have not finished Class 10. But in our northern states — Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Bihar — we still have younger girls, 16, 17, 18 years old, who have dropped out of school and need some support in coming back. Getting those who fail back quickly is another part of the Second Chance programme that is developing: if you fail in Class 10, how do we quickly get you back into the mainstream, so that ten years of investment doesn't go to waste?

Neharika Vohra: Absolutely. Pratham was founded in 1995 in the slums of Mumbai by Madhav Chavan and Farida Lambay, with an almost audacious simplicity of purpose. You joined in 1996, a year later. What brought you from Chicago back to India, and to Pratham?

Rukmini Banerji: I went abroad, as many people do, as a student for graduate studies, but I always wondered what relevance and applicability the things I was studying inside the classroom had outside it. At the University of Chicago, there were actually quite a few opportunities to connect to the immediate context. As a student, to make some money on the side, I did part-time work with a department that was developing a maths curriculum for primary schools, and the materials and tools needed to be tested — so there was a connection to the Chicago public school system. At the time, not just the University of Chicago but other universities too had deep links into the public school system. That's how I was exposed to the idea that you don't have to be in an ivory tower — you can be in the classroom and in research at the same time.

One final thing made a big difference. For my own PhD, I used secondary data, partly because it was very expensive to come to India for primary data collection, so actual groundwork and fieldwork couldn't take place. So, over a period of almost three years, I volunteered two or three times a week at lunchtime in a local government school. In those days, the area around the University of Chicago was what was known as a rough area — I suppose the equivalent of some of our slums, though different in character, more violent and more isolated. I taught writing to seventh-grade children, and that really got me thinking, beyond my own research, about children of a similar age in our own context. I always wanted to come back to India, and I did, a couple of years after finishing my PhD. But it was this connection to a larger school system, and to communities, that I felt I must have if I was going to think about how all this education business could make a difference to children's lives.

Neharika Vohra: So good education can actually bring the right people to the right place as well. Almost nine years after you joined, Pratham launched the first ASER — the Annual Status of Education Report — a nationwide household survey involving 500 organisations and 25,000 volunteers, which gave India its first district-level picture of learning outcomes. What was the thinking behind the survey, why did you start thinking about this problem, and how has ASER made an impact as it has gone along?

Rukmini Banerji: While we did the first thing called ASER in 2005, the thinking and the work had been evolving for quite a few years before that. The initial years were largely in Mumbai, and even then you could see enrolment increasing — having all children go to school was a national priority, a local priority, a family priority. In those early years in Bombay, we worked with two kinds of children. I always say there were children who were left out — very visible, because they were out of school — and the question was what to do to bring them in. And then there were those who were left behind, who are less visible because they're in school and in the class, so you expect that their education will happen anyway. The more out-of-school children we brought into school, the more the municipal schools would say, what about the children we already have — what should we do about them? Everybody had a view on why these children were getting left behind. Teachers would say parents don't pay attention, and that's why their education is weak; parents would say teachers don't pay attention, and that's why their education is weak.

Working with both out-of-school and in-school children, we kept facing the same thing: you could be eight years old, but whether you were in school or out, you weren't really equipped to deal with what Class 3 or 4 expected of you. So there was a whole variety of experiments going on. In fact, the first study that the Poverty Action Lab — now J-PAL — did was on what can be done to really help children; it was a remedial education programme, about how we can help children catch up. Through all of that, the work also began to spread to other places — that study itself was done partly in Baroda and partly in Mumbai, over two years. So clearly there was a problem. But what could be done about it? We also needed to define the problem: "left behind" means what — left behind in what, and how?

So from probably 2000 onwards, we were grappling with understanding the problem — and if you can articulate the problem, I think you're almost halfway to finding an answer. Across lots of classrooms and lots of work in the community, you could see that if you don't know how to read, nothing else can happen. So reading is fundamental. Then, what about reading? We started breaking it up: reading means reading letters, reading words, reading sentences, and so on. Today everybody talks about foundational literacy and numeracy, but at that time the question was what the key to unlocking progress was. Reading was clearly one, and simple arithmetic was another — perhaps even more than in language, in arithmetic you have to master the previous set of concepts before you can move to the next.

We were trying to figure this out because we wanted a solution. There was also a lot of frustration within us at the time. Even in that first J-PAL study, you'd spend a whole year working with children and somehow get them up to a basic level — but by then the child is nine or ten years old, and we needed to get them to a level at which they could actually propel themselves

through the system. So at some point — I don't know exactly when, maybe 2001 or 2002 — we took a decision: let's take some people, take one month, and see what is possible in a month. Why one month? It's just a unit, and at the time, pulling people out of whatever they were doing for more than a month would probably have been difficult. There was a group of maybe 40 or 50 people, wherever we were working — in Mumbai, elsewhere in Maharashtra and beyond — and we said, take a group of children, not the very small ones but those in Class 3 and upwards, since they've reached a certain cognitive level. They could be out-of-school or in-school children. Each of us would take our group of maybe 20 or 25 children and see how far we could go in one month.

Because we were working in different places — and I don't know how we were communicating, since nobody had cell phones; we must have been meeting or talking on landlines — we felt the need for a common vocabulary to explain to each other what we were doing. The first piece of that vocabulary was: who are my children? I have to describe my children to you, and you have to describe yours to me. We needed a common way of talking about them, and if we were talking about basic reading or basic maths, I needed to say what they could and couldn't do. What today is called the ASER reading tool was actually just a simple way of describing the composition of the children I had, or you had — I have five children who are struggling even to recognise letters, and five others who are reading very fluently, but they're all in the 8-to-10 age group. Creating that common vocabulary, and understanding how much variation there is even within the same class or set of classes, was the first step. It let me describe who my children were.

Second, what is the pathway I need to take them through? In reading, we could see that as soon as children start reading letters, letters come together to form words — yes, you may need a bit of barakhadi to bring vowels and consonants together — and then you move to paragraphs and stories. But we could also see that the children had a lot of oral strength. So if you were teaching them to read in their own language, you weren't starting from zero; you were starting from a position of oral strength, and you had to teach them the techniques of decoding and so on. By 2003 or so, we had this process — of course you have to keep working at it to make it better. We were largely urban in those days, so we thought, if we go to a new place, the place to begin is to understand who is there. So we started doing what we called village report cards. You go to a rural area — and since we were urban people, we had to understand the context; maybe there was no need for what we were doing. The village report card was like a census, but you couldn't do it alone. You'd go mohalla by mohalla, and once you started, people would come and help, because it was a very easy thing to do.

Then you want a reaction from people, because if there is a problem, you want a solution. By 2003 or 2004 we were already working in over a hundred blocks in the country, and this process seemed useful everywhere. There are hundreds of stories about those village-level discussions, which I won't bore you with, but I must tell you one. This was a village in UP — Sultanpur or Pratapgarh, somewhere in central UP. The normal protocol was that when you went to a village, you told the sarpanch or pradhan what you were there to do. This particular sarpanch was a very busy man with a big dairy business, and he said, many people come to do surveys, go ahead. Three or four days later, when the survey was done, I went back and told him that what we had come to do was done. He asked me, where should I sign? I said there was actually no place to sign, because it wasn't going anywhere. He said, please check with your seniors — when data is collected, it goes up. I got a bit offended and said, actually, I am the boss. He was not impressed. He said, if you're the boss, why are you here? I also noticed you don't have a car.

But this conversation got him engaged, because he was curious about who I was — and I was a little annoyed that he wasn't paying attention. So I said, let's say you have 100 children, of whom 85 go to school. He said, I know that. I said, of those, 50 don't know how to read. He said, not possible. First, he said it was a lie. I said it's not a lie, and the villagers also said, they've been doing this for three days and we've helped them. Then "it's a lie" changed to "this is impossible — they go to school, how can it be?" Anyway, it got his attention, and he said there's only one way to find out — I'll do it myself. He called the children who were around, and by the sixth child he said, my God, this is happening in front of my eyes, and I had no idea. We have to do something about this.

I describe this story — and I use it a lot — because you need to go through this whole process. Just because you have data doesn't mean people will digest it. You have to feel it, you have to question it, and once you actually understand the problem — he was then on the warpath: I have to fix this. Many experiences like this made us feel that if this dynamic exists at the village or community level, all you have to do is take it to a higher level so that the whole country does it that way. It isn't that we're only holding up a mirror to show how bad or good things are; it's to get you involved in your local context — and remember, as a country we were moving very fast towards universalising enrolment. So the root of ASER was in all of this. The important thing was to have a local connection, a local feel for the problem, so that more people feel motivated to say, we will do something about it. At one level it's a big problem, but at another level — teaching children how to read — there are people everywhere who can help do that. In that sense, it's not like HIV or climate change.

So ASER evolved from this. There are many other pieces, but basically, at the village level you do a census, and at the district level you do a representative sample. If a district-level organisation or institution undertakes it, some of that local feel can be captured, because there will be at least 30 to 60 people at the district level who have done it, belonging to an institution, who can then engage with the district-level equivalent of the village pradhan or sarpanch to take it forward. So the beginning of ASER, I would say, was: "Jaano, Pehchaano, Socho aur Kuch Karo" — know, recognise, think, and do something.

Neharika Vohra: Very nice. I've always been curious about how Pratham went from one slum to 26 states. How did that scaling happen?

Rukmini Banerji: I remember this — it was 2 October 2005. It was a holiday anyway, and I think it may even have been a Sunday. By then many of these things had happened, and sometime during that day Madhav said, why don't we do this across the whole country? Now, one bad habit Pratham people have is that they don't say no — and often you don't know what you're getting into. I also said, we've done it in so many villages and a few things at the district level, so why not? India had more than 500 districts even then, and we were only in some states, so it was a big adventure. One thing I always think about, looking back, is that Madhav was very good at naming things. ASER means ASER — "impact" — but of course it also stands for Annual Status of Education Report, and that "A" meant no less: "A" meant we had to do it every year.

At the time, I think we were taken aback — how would it be possible to do the entire country? — but we didn't dwell on it. In some states there was a Pratham presence, but it was thin. I remember one of our young colleagues in Uttar Pradesh was in charge of 20 districts. What did that mean? That in 20 districts, he had to find a partner. We didn't have money, so people had to want to do this. How do you convince people? It was a big exercise in convincing people to come together. It's always good to have money, but if you don't, you have to be much more persuasive. I remember that in Punjab or Haryana somewhere, one of my colleagues arrived in her district and went to a PCO — a public calling booth — and started calling whatever names she had. The PCO owner, who was listening, asked her, what are you doing, making so many calls? When she explained, he gave her ten more names. And there was another place where someone was taking their motorcycle to fill petrol every two days, and the petrol pump owner asked, where do you go that you use so much petrol? When it was explained to him, he said, for this, at least for a month, keep coming and I'll fill your petrol. That's how you bring people in, so that they feel they want to be part of it too.

In the first two years, we were like missionaries — we went and found like-minded people. Sometimes people did a good job and could do it again; sometimes people said, my God, this was great fun. And believe me, in the initial years, some of the places in India you'd think would be difficult weren't — Kashmir was not difficult. In Kashmir, even to this day, when we go to district colleges, lecturers and students join in happily, because they feel it is part of something — a learning, going out into the field. I myself have seen more of India because of ASER. I'm making it sound simple, and it's actually not that complicated, because it's a simple idea that people can understand and relate to, and it opens up a new experience. So many young people in our country who study in district colleges have never been anywhere except their own village, the district headquarters, and their maternal grandparents' home. When they're given a list of randomly selected villages — I used to do a lot of training in the early years — people would say, "How do I even ask?" I'd say, ask around where the village is, look at the block. People talk about the results a lot, but I think the process itself is very invigorating. It happens in a very short period — you only do the survey over a weekend, you're not alone, people go in twos — and in those two days, I feel, whoever does it is transformed, and it spreads goodwill in whichever village you go to, about coming together to do something.

So the spread across India happened in this very organic way. Even in the first ASER, we reached close to 475 districts. The team we sent to the Northeast — which has about 75 districts — were such young people. One was from Manipur, whose parents had educated him and sent him out of Manipur so he could build a better future. When we sent him back to Manipur, his parents said, "What has happened?" They went away for three months, did 15 districts and came back. Probably in the old days, when people took ships and sailed across oceans, this is how it must have been.

Neharika Vohra: That's right. Another piece of pioneering work Pratham has done is Teaching at the Right Level, which J-PAL at MIT has helped you implement in partnership with more than half of India's state governments. How did this methodology emerge, and what do you see as its impact?

Rukmini Banerji: As I was describing, ASER and the teaching all happened together, because you had to understand where the children were and then figure out a way of really teaching them. In the period between 2001 or 2002 and 2005, they were the same thing: the assessment was the first step in understanding children, and the next step was the methodology to teach them. After 2005, ASER became the assessment part. At that time, Teaching at the Right Level had a simple name — "Learning to Read." Later we called it "Kamaal," meaning miracle, because we felt that children learning in such a short time

was like a miracle. Then J-PAL needed an English name to talk about it elsewhere, and so it got the name Teaching at the Right Level. These two things were connected and continue to be, although you can always do an assessment on its own.

For Teaching at the Right Level, the first step is to know who your children are, to group them by the level they're at, and then do activities appropriate to their level to move them to where they should be. So even here, the key components are quite simple. The fundamental philosophy we've worked with is to keep things simple so that many people can join. When you make things complicated, expensive or highly technical, it's difficult for people to join. We are a big country with many people, and most people want something better for their own children, for the children in their community or in their school. So keep it simple — and the work J-PAL has done with us is to test every iteration for effectiveness, so that it's also credible. It's an ongoing process; frankly, even 20 years later, we're still trying to improve how we reach millions of children. And then, just like with ASER, once you've done it yourself, how do you pass it on and share it with others? The partnerships with governments also grew from that process: if there is a problem that you can see — and perhaps ASER shows it to you — how do we come up with a possible solution that can help?

Neharika Vohra: Very nice. All of this requires money, and at this scale the amounts are quite high. You've had international donors, foundations, Indian government programmes and CSR. Has the funding landscape shifted over the three decades you've been involved? And has the funders' definition of impact affected how you look at some of your work?

Rukmini Banerji: Of course the funding landscape has changed, but fundamentally, in the support we used to get and continue to get, I see three or four major types of funders. One was Indian corporates — now, in a more organised way, called CSR, but before that there were corporates who supported such work. Our chairman in the initial stages was Mr. Vaghul, and ICICI was a big partner; at that time it wasn't called CSR, but they supported us. Then there are foundations, both in India and abroad, that have supported civil society work in other parts of the world — they played an important role. And a third, continuing and important source is the diaspora: Indians living abroad — in our case largely in the US — who feel they got there because of education and want to support their own state or district, or India generally. Those have been the three major buckets. There have been governments as well; earlier it was easier for government to support these things, and now there are more regulations and processes.

Within each of these buckets there have been changes. CSR has become bigger and tighter, but it is certainly providing a lot of support, and each kind of funding is aligned to a certain kind of work. For example, CSR funders often want the work to be in their factory area, or in a district of some importance to them. Individuals often want a personal connection to a particular place. It's usually foundations, or organisations like UNICEF, that can see that working with governments is risky but high-impact — and slowly corporates are coming into that space too. But because of today's regulations, they need external evaluation and measurement as part of their mandate, which sometimes makes it difficult for them to fund long-run, uncertain projects.

Now, the question of impact. It's a funny thing — maybe because both our founders, Madhav Chavan and Farida Lambay, were university professors, evidence and impact were part of Pratham from the beginning. I remember that in the early years we used to say there are a lot of needs, and resources are always limited, but our own capability to meet those needs is also limited. So you have to weigh your own capability, the need and the resources — should we work with young children, or with school children? — and that has to be debated internally. So this measurement of impact, efficiency or effectiveness came naturally to us, because we had big ambitions but tight resources and limited capability. J-PAL, for example, has worked with us for many years, but we never saw it as an evaluation of our work. We saw it as a partnership, and so did they, and we felt we gained when people with very different skills came alongside us to look at what we were doing and give us feedback.

Today, impact measurement has become a requirement and part of the funding landscape, but I feel it works if it's aligned with curiosity — it's all about curiosity. You have to be curious, and a little bit sceptical: am I doing the best I can, or should I be doing something else? If organisations, whether outside government or inside it, have that healthy mix of curiosity and scepticism, then asking "how am I doing?" comes naturally, and that's a healthy thing. And if that aligns with what the world requires, so be it. But it shouldn't be that someone asks you to report your impact when you're not interested yourself — then it's a waste of resources and effort.

Neharika Vohra: I like the two things you're talking about — curiosity and scepticism. That healthy mix is very important for all leaders, in all sectors.

Rukmini Banerji: I'd add a healthy level of frustration too — can I be doing better? Being a little restless — not thinking the whole world is falling apart, but having that restlessness, and building it into your teams from the beginning. Without it, I think it takes you longer.

Neharika Vohra: Yes — a little bit of hunger. Pratham now also has an international wing, working in about 16 countries in sub-Saharan Africa. What took you there, and how has it affected the organisational identity of Pratham in India?

Rukmini Banerji: The two things you talked about, ASER and Teaching at the Right Level, have each had their own international journeys. We were doing ASER in the way I just described, but there were others outside, including some foundation funders, who felt that what was happening here might be useful elsewhere. The Hewlett Foundation, a long-standing funder of both ASER and Teaching at the Right Level, brought several people from sub-Saharan Africa to see ASER. The first group came from Kenya, Uganda and Tanzania, because I think Hewlett felt the circumstances were in some ways similar. Very interestingly, as early as 2007, an organisation from Pakistan also came to visit — in those days it was easy to travel back and forth. I remember being invited to a conference in Pakistan in 2006 or 2007, and I wrote back saying I couldn't come because we were doing ASER. They wrote back asking, what is ASER?

So people came and saw what we did. Typically, international exchanges happen in some Western country, at a conference — it wasn't like that. People came here and spent time in the field with us; we explained whatever we did, and we also told them the mistakes we had made, so that they could make their own mistakes. The ASER approach went back to these countries, where it was modified and adapted to their own conditions. Very interestingly, we called it ASER, but in Kenya it's called Uwezo — apparently in Kiswahili, uwezo means capability. So they gave it their own name, and their own meaning behind the name. It looked a bit different everywhere, because we said, take it and grow it in whatever way you like. Every now and then, if they wanted some help, they would invite us — and sometimes they invited us just to celebrate. That's how ASER travelled.

With Teaching at the Right Level, there were one or two early forays, but the real push came when J-PAL, which has a presence in many parts of the world, was asking what effective interventions in education looked like. Between 2000 and 2015 there had been six or seven evaluations of Teaching at the Right Level, so they could point to that evidence and say, this is something that has worked. Many countries in sub-Saharan Africa and elsewhere also had high schooling levels but very varied learning. So J-PAL was a big carrier of the message. Then, around 2017 or 2018, a funding group called Co-Impact invited J-PAL and Pratham to come together to create an organisational approach for doing Teaching at the Right Level in sub-Saharan Africa. We worked together, starting in a few countries, and the idea was also to create an organisation that would do this work in sub-Saharan Africa. That organisation today is called Teaching at the Right Level Africa, and it is largely African. J-PAL and Pratham were founders, but we have now handed it over.

Because of Indian regulations, our international team is quite separate: those who work in India don't work on the international team, and those on the international team aren't connected to the work in India. The international team is like a technical support team. They helped Teaching at the Right Level Africa set up and take the work to many countries, and with the African countries they did the initial trainings and the initial development of the programme; as organisations — or governments — become more able to take it on, the team moves on to other things. Today our international team supports the Teaching at the Right Level Africa organisation, but also works in Latin America, sometimes directly with governments, sometimes with NGOs; in Morocco; and some new work is now beginning in Cambodia — because the problem of children falling behind is quite common in developing countries. And because Teaching at the Right Level is now quite well known, governments and other organisations often reach out to understand what it is and what it takes to implement it.

Neharika Vohra: So if you do good work, it gets recognised, and it makes good friends.

Rukmini Banerji: And if you have good friends, they carry the message. The thing is — people probably say this about India in other contexts as well — a Tanzanian once said to me, if something works for a billion people, it's likely to work for the next five billion people too. So, made in India, definitely, but of use to other people — so why not?

Neharika Vohra: Why not, of course. What is the size of your team at Pratham?

Rukmini Banerji: In India, across all our programmes, there are between 5,000 and 5,500 full-time people. Our international team is much smaller — about 40 to 50 people.

Neharika Vohra: And of these 5,000-plus people, there are professionals, people from the best colleges, and then a large number of people from the villages and districts?

Rukmini Banerji: Yes. In fact, if I look at our national leadership team of about 20 to 25 people, it's a very interesting mix — and perhaps people like you who work on organisational development can help us think it through. We have people who have risen from the ground, and professionals who come in with skills they have built elsewhere. And I often find that it's this mix of the two types of personalities and skills that really helps us in a unique way. For example, the head of our UP

education team, Losaf Malik, was a balwadi teacher in a Bombay slum when I joined Pratham, and today she heads one of our biggest programmes. The head of our Karnataka team, Manjumma, was doing his PhD at the Indian Institute of Science and, for whatever reason, left and started working with Pratham. They are both leaders within Pratham — one who could have done a PhD in physics or something and moved on, and one who came from being a balwadi teacher. I don't know if this combination is unique — I haven't worked in many other organisations — but I'm very proud that we can have this mix.

Neharika Vohra: And I guess it contributes to the kind of conversations that happen. So that's about 20 or 25 people — what about the rest?

Rukmini Banerji: Think of it this way: every state has a state leadership, which typically has a leader and then people working on teaching and learning, people working on measurement, and people working on operations. Even among these state leaders, some have risen from the ground and some have come in later. Across the 5,000, I'd say probably 500 to 600 are at this kind of leadership level, whether at the district, state or national level. But a very large part are at the ground level. What the ground level looks like depends on the programme. In our direct programmes, Pratham people interact with children directly — teaching in schools, working in the community, connecting with parents. We call these our laboratories; in every state we have at least 50 to 100 or more villages where we do this directly. Then there are the partnerships, where we work with the district or state government, and one Pratham person may be integrated into the government's district-level team, or three people into its state-level team. So we have both kinds of programmes, and a large part of our teams are either directly at the ground level or at the district level, depending on the model.

Neharika Vohra: How would you rate their motivation levels, and what keeps them motivated?

Rukmini Banerji: Of course, you'd have to talk to them, but I feel people are quite motivated, and I can only speak to what motivates me. I think when you see that you are contributing directly to some kind of progress, that gives you motivation. You're also motivated when you have a good idea and the space to try it out. I'm sure we're not good at pay, but I find a lot of people stay with us for a long time. We now have cohorts who have grown up with us — people I have known for nearly 30 years, since they were practically children themselves, whose own children are now going to college. That worries me a bit, because I don't think Pratham started out as a lifetime-career kind of place, so we have to learn how to create pathways inside so that there is progress and growth.

But when I look at people who leave Pratham, what do they do? Typically they start their own organisation or enterprise. Of course, some join others, but there's something about being a little entrepreneurial, wanting to try your own thing — and I hope that in Pratham there is space to do that, and that we are able to incubate. We haven't done a systematic study of our alumni, but I see them around all the time and I know many of them, and I hope they got that grounding in Pratham and were then able to go out and do things. In my time, when I was in college or soon after, people went to Hindustan Unilever as a boot camp. If we are that, then first, we are proud of it, and second, I feel we should see ourselves not just as carrying out what we do but as creating the leaders of tomorrow. Right now we are doing it unconsciously. But when I look around at how many education organisations in India are headed by ex-Pratham people, I feel very proud, and I feel we must have done something right.

Neharika Vohra: You came to this work as an economist, trained in quantitative reasoning, but you've spent a career building an organisation that takes data seriously without reducing everybody to a data point. How has that tension shaped you, and how have you kept both sides alive?

Rukmini Banerji: My being in university was really just the usual path — if you did reasonably well in school, you went to college, did reasonably well there, and so on. But even while I was in graduate school, I realised I wanted something much more on the ground, and I've been very lucky to find that place. I really like this very basic question: what is the problem, and how do we understand it? If you've got the problem and you understand it, you can't walk away — you have to do something about it. But how do you do something about it systematically? How do you go back and think about what you did well and what you didn't? The growth of Pratham, and my own growth inside Pratham, has enabled this in a very natural way.

Many years ago, when we were still in Bombay — I first joined Pratham in August 1996 — we were involved with 150 balwadis, and there was a lot of talk at the time: we're working at scale, how will we manage? And on 14 November 1998 — I remember the date because it's Children's Day — we had a big event in Mumbai, and by then we were associated with over 3,500 balwadis. That growth from 150 to 3,500 in just over two years was phenomenal. While we were in the middle of it, questions about how you really know what's happening, what quality is, what scale is, and what you should measure were constantly being discussed. We had a pro bono group of young people from McKinsey helping us come up with metrics, because someone on our board must have felt we needed professional advice. At the same time, I was working with about 50 balwadi teachers, asking them, what is a good balwadi, and how will we know? The metrics the balwadi teachers came up

with and the metrics McKinsey came up with — more than half were common. The difference was that when the metrics came from the balwadi teachers, they owned them.

So I really like this way in which you can get absolutely ordinary people to think analytically about these things — what are we curious about, how do we come up with methods we can all use? And then you can also partner with people like J-PAL, who bring in the rigour. J-PAL never looked down on us, even on our own measurement work, and of course we looked up to them. There's a whole continuum of data, analysis and rigour, which can be done in a very simple way or a very sophisticated way — that's what I really like, and I've been able to do it. When you're building out big programmes, if this DNA can remain, then I think you are somewhere staying true to the original purpose of why this was all being done, and whether it is making a difference.

Neharika Vohra: In fact, someone has said that to be simple is not to be simplistic. You need a lot of complex thinking to actually put something out simply.

Rukmini Banerji: Yes, yes. A very close friend of mine from college and graduate school is an econometrician, and she used to say, "I never understand what you people do at Pratham." But when 2005 came and she could see a sample of lakhs, she couldn't resist coming in — Wilima Wadhwa is today our statistician, because she said, this is too much of a temptation.

Neharika Vohra: Coming back to your people and your teams — how do you build capacity, and make sure the team feels capable and up to the mark?

Rukmini Banerji: This is an ongoing process — just yesterday we had a big conversation about how much more we need to do and how to do it. But I think it's a combination. There's bringing people together — call it training, call it orientation — around common frameworks, because across, say, our education programmes, there's a common set of principles of operating, of pedagogy, and so on. And then there's letting people loose and seeing what they can do. Right from the beginning, somebody trusted me to do whatever I was doing — so why should I not trust you? What is so special about me that only I can be trusted? So there's this formal understanding, and then building it up. Especially for teaching and learning, everybody in Pratham does a stint teaching children themselves, so they feel that this isn't just the Teaching at the Right Level manual — it can happen, because I did it. To the extent possible, we always say: if you haven't done it yourself, don't tell someone else to do it.

Even with ASER, to this day the senior team — including Wilima, myself, anybody — does one rehearsal every year, to make sure that what we are asking 25,000 people to do can be done, and that I have done it. So: do it yourself, learn from the people around you in an organised way, then trust others to follow, and keep some simple support mechanisms in place, because none of this can be taught in one short session. There have to be ways in which you learn, you see it demonstrated, you do it. For example, in our direct programmes, someone — whether from measurement, operations or teaching and learning — will visit you from time to time, look at that part of the work and understand your point of view, so that whatever model we build next incorporates the understanding from the ground. In that sense, Pratham is quite a flat organisation; most people spend a lot of time on the ground, both to understand what we are doing well and to build the right kind of capacity.

I stepped down as CEO just about ten days ago, and Meenakshi has taken over as CEO. The person who was helping us with that process came and spent two days with the national leadership team, and she said, you didn't tell me that the head of Pratham has to know at least Hindi and one or two other Indian languages. It had never crossed anybody's mind that this needed to be said, but our operating language often isn't English, because there's a whole range of languages. The flip side is that at the state level, English speakers carrying laptops can dominate the conversation, and some of our people don't know English well — so yes, we should strengthen English and that kind of communication. On the other hand, at the ground and district level, our people sometimes have an advantage, because they are very much from there. So it's a question of what capacity, for whom, and how. But I'd say it's a combination of something structured, some hand-holding, and a large amount of trust — that if you know what your goal is, you will get it done, even if the process doesn't stick exactly to what I would have done.

Neharika Vohra: Perfect. As you move into a senior advisor role, what is your vision for Pratham? And could you also talk a little about how Pratham has managed succession, which I think is a huge issue for many social impact organisations, where the founder holds on for as long as they can?

Rukmini Banerji: We've had an interesting journey. First, we have two co-founders, and then several people who are almost like co-founders. Around 2015, as I said, I became CEO, but neither Madhav nor Farida actually left — they stepped aside. Madhav started focusing on particular areas — what Pratham's view should be, and evolving work on children, youth, learning and technology — something he had long been interested in and has continued to go deeper into. Farida used to be

vice principal of the College of Social Work at Nirmala Niketan in Mumbai, and she retired from there around the same time. She'd had two full-time jobs, Pratham and Nirmala Niketan, and like twins, each thought she loved the other more. Now we were her one and only love. When I became CEO, she said something to me that nobody in my life has ever said: tell me what to do, and I'll do it. She has spent the last ten years really working on the people side of things, which allowed me to focus on programmes — because someone of her stature and experience was handling the people aspect of an organisation of 5,000 or 6,000. So my two co-founders have been very busy adding value to what we do.

In my own case, I went to my board and said we need to start thinking about succession. The board's first reaction was, why? But I felt — and I think COVID had something to do with it — that we needed to build more leadership: not just my own succession, but my 20 to 25 people moving up to the next level, and the people below them taking on additional or higher responsibility. It has to be a process that runs down the chain. I'm not saying we've done it perfectly, but I always ask any leader within Pratham, at any level: who is your right hand and left hand? If there isn't even one, how are you a leader? Some people do this quite well and some don't, but we have to create the opportunities for people to move ahead. So it's about succession, but also, every few years, moving on to the next thing — and the next thing doesn't always have to be higher; it can be different.

When we're in an environment of expansion, this isn't a problem. But I worry about next year — the global and domestic situation is such that I think resources will be much tighter. In a tightening situation, what do you do? I often say that in a tightening situation you go deep, and in a more prosperous situation you go wide, and at any level you should have both experiences, because going deep gives you one kind of learning and going wide gives you another. To some extent, COVID and periods of financial tightness teach you that you have to go up and down. I hope many of our leaders understand that today you may be leading 100 people and tomorrow 10, but either way you are a leader. So what is it that you have that is extra, that makes you different from others?

Neharika Vohra: So, Rukmini, any regrets?

Rukmini Banerji: I wouldn't call them regrets, but I do feel that over the last ten years you pay a price for being a leader, because as a leader there are things you have to do, as opposed to things you want to do. It's not a regret, but sitting in this position and looking at everything in Pratham, I can now see which are my favourite things — and obviously I haven't been able to give those as much time as I would have liked. Again, I am a very privileged and lucky person, because there are many favourite things and lots of interesting things. And there are things you have to do — fundraising, governance — things you should do because you need to learn them. But I'm very happy to be relieved of some of those. It's very new, so I also have to let go of some more things, and focus on areas where perhaps we haven't invested. I'm also looking more widely — I was just in Africa last week. When you're a little further away, you can see that their Teaching at the Right Level and ours have many commonalities, and I'm in a position to step back and bring some things together. That's something you can only do when you've moved away a little.

Neharika Vohra: Of course. So you're not stepping out, you're just stepping aside and taking on newer things.

Rukmini Banerji: I'm stepping aside, and I think it's also my responsibility to give Meenakshi the space she needs. I was given the space, and she needs to be given the space. But while we do that, I hope I can still contribute to the overall growth of what we're doing, in India and internationally — the way I've seen my seniors contribute without getting in my way. And there is also an ecosystem. We all contribute, at a certain stage, to a larger ecosystem. Sometimes people from other organisations want to come and have a chat, and I feel your door should be open, because in the end we are creating public resources — public goods. The more people who think in a similar way, the richer we are as a whole sector.

Neharika Vohra: Very nice. My last question is for young people making career choices, or even mid-career people who are thinking, enough of the corporate world, now I want to work in another sector. What would you advise them? What would you want them to know before they come into one of these roles?

Rukmini Banerji: Many people ask me this, and I always say: if you have the flexibility and the time, take a month. If you want to come to Pratham, say — we are very open — spend time on the ground. If you only sit with the senior people, you'll get only one view. If you can, look at the real work, and if that real work excites you and you feel there's a lot to learn there — you may bring a lot of skills, but if you feel there's a lot to learn — then jump. But not if you find yourself asking why we do things this way or that way. I would say I've been very fortunate — I've had a very exciting life. Not in a very big way, but every day you see something that makes you think, we never thought of it like this. That's partly because you can go anywhere and meet people from the most senior levels to the ground level. This kind of wide landscape and flexibility is, I think, possible in our sector.

In some other kinds of work, it's probably more regimented and more hierarchical. So if you enjoy the wide experience — big problems, but a wide experience — and don't need a tight structure, then this is the place for you. But if you do better in a much more structured setting, it may not be. Somebody once asked me what their growth possibilities would be, and I had no idea. I had a young man who was leaving Infosys, and he came and asked, what's my job description? I said, spend a month — I'm sending you to UP and Bihar. When you come back, tell me your view, I'll ask my colleagues for their view, and if it's going to work out, all these views will come together in one place. He has been with us for 15 years now. But I don't give a job description — you have to go and see.

Neharika Vohra: Very nice. I love that you asked, do you have something to learn? That's an excellent point, because that's often the hook that really makes you stay.

Rukmini Banerji: Yes, there has to be something intrinsic that comes from you, and that gets rewarded or supported by your landscape. But it's wrong to expect that the landscape will give you that.

Neharika Vohra: Absolutely. Thank you so much, Rukmini, for your time and for your openness in sharing your work. I hope you continue to do as well, and even better, as you go along.